



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

‘Sports Governance Act is essential to address ecosystem of sport’

“The National Sports Governance Act is essential to address the complete ecosystem of sport,” said Kunal (left), Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, at the PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

“When we see the issues which are plaguing the ecosystem, which hinges on the development of sport as a driver of the economy and as a vehicle of social change, the good governance framework is critical. This Bill, and now Act, is built upon three core pillars: athlete centricity, good governance and global alignment. So, it is holistically addressing the core issues which are required for the successful functioning of a federation, the successful participation of athletes, proper development of the sporting pyramid from top to bottom and adherence to the Olympic Charter and international regulations,” he said.

Kunal explained that the drafting process drew on both Indian precedents and international models. “The principle of good governance was the broad framework under which we had functioned. The draft constitution of the IOA, formed under the direction of the Supreme

Court, also served as a good base for framing our draft Bill. We also looked at international practices – the US system, then Australia, the UK and France, which all have courts of sport. So, these international best practices were thoroughly studied. Our own sports court, its functioning, different court orders – everything was studied deeply, and after due consultation, this Bill was framed.”

The session, titled Breaking Down the National Sports Governance Act, featured Kunal and Vidushpat Singhania, Managing Partner at Krida Legal and one of India’s foremost sports and gaming lawyers, in conversation with *Sportstar* Editor Ayon Sengupta.

Singhania highlighted the stabilising effect the new law could bring to Indian sport. “There is going to be more stability in the federations, which is actually the major requirement, especially if they are going to bid for major events like the Olympics, the Commonwealth Games and even world championships. You need stability. Even the leagues which are there need stability,” he said.

The Act requires every national sports body to have a general body with equal representation from affiliate members, alongside designated ex officio members.

Singhania pointed out that this framework should not be seen as undue interference by international bodies.

“I have had the chance to deal with international federations regarding sports governance in India. This autonomy question is a googly that is often thrown. The sports governance standards have been in existence since 1975. At no time has an international federation really said that imposing good governance norms is bad for Indian sport. Their issue is that the government cannot elect somebody to the federation’s board as an executive committee member or determine who is going to be part of it.”

Kunal weighed in: “Good governance norms are now well-recognised globally. Even the International Olympic Committee has laid down principles of good governance. While framing the bill, we held extensive discussions with major federations worldwide and studied international practices. The Act provides a framework — it does not in any way hinge on the autonomy of federations. Instead, it lays out broad principles for how federations should be run, how disputes should be resolved, and how smooth transitions can take place during elections.”